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Functional Bureau Strategy

Bureau of Consular Affairs

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1. Executive Statement and Mission Statement

Executive Statement

The Bureau of Consular Affairs (CA) provides consular services to and protects the interests of U.S. citizens overseas; facilitates international travel by U.S. citizens; and adjudicates the visa applications of foreign nationals who seek to visit, study, work in, or immigrate to the United States. CA represents the United States abroad as its personnel directly engage with tens of thousands of people each day, and its work sets the tone for many bilateral relationships.

CA's first goal and highest priority is to protect the lives and serve the interests of U.S. citizens overseas. Millions of U.S. citizens have a valid passport and travel overseas regularly. They are used to immediate access to services and information, whether at home or abroad, from a desktop or a mobile device. This raises expectations that the U.S. government will respond to a citizen's needs wherever they may travel or reside. CA aims to provide and improve access to passport and citizens services in keeping with current standards of digital service. Internet and mobile technology provide CA the means to communicate effectively and efficiently as well as ensure equitable access to safety and security information, so U.S. citizens can make informed decisions about traveling and residing overseas.

CA is dedicated to facilitating legitimate travel while protecting U.S. borders. CA's mission includes the issuance of passports to U.S. citizens, in addition to the adjudication of visas for foreign nationals seeking to visit the United States for leisure, business, or educational purposes, as well as for those who wish to immigrate to the United States. Establishing sound and effective U.S. border security begins with the issuance of secure error-free passports to U.S. citizens and visas to foreign nationals who qualify for them, and denial of these travel documents to those who do not. Facilitation of legitimate travel has a tangible impact on the U.S. domestic economy and U.S. business interests. It improves person-to-person relationships and builds knowledge about the United States, both critical to improving the influence of the United States.

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None of this can be done without investment in CA's technological, financial, and human resources. CA continues its IT modernization progress, driven by public demand and the need for greater efficiency and data security. To accomplish this, CA continues to look for ways to stabilize the fee-based Consular and Border Security Programs account. Legislative restrictions prohibit the bureau from retaining fees for the full cost of all services, particularly those that impact our ability to serve U.S. citizens overseas. Well-trained Foreign Service, Civil Service, contractor, and Locally Employed Staff worldwide make passport and visa decisions that improve services to U.S. citizens overseas. CA draws on a full range of recruitment, hiring, and assignment strategies, along with a strong professional development program, to ensure that the bureau has a workforce that reflects, and supports, the diversity of the United States.

Mission Statement

CA is represented around the world in more than 230 embassies and consulates and charged with providing routine and emergency services to U.S. citizens abroad and visa services to those who wish to travel to the United States. Domestically, CA supports the passport needs of U.S. citizens at 29 passport agencies and centers and a network of public offices managed by other federal, state, and local government agencies/offices that accept passport applications.

CA carries out the Department's most important mission overseas – the protection of U.S. citizens and their interests. Consular officers are the U.S. government's first provider of services for U.S. citizens overseas, whether registering the birth or death of a U.S. citizen, repatriating remains, providing voting assistance in U.S. elections, or helping citizens in need to return to the United States. Consular officers also assist incarcerated and missing persons, abducted children and their families, travelers threatened by natural disasters, and during public health crises or civil unrest.

We facilitate legitimate travel to and from the United States while protecting U.S. borders. Passport adjudications entail provision of a service and making border security decisions. CA serves U.S. citizens intending international travel through passport issuance, while protecting

the integrity of the U.S. passport as proof of U.S. citizenship. CA prioritizes enhancing the customer experience while improving passport security and timely service to U.S. citizens.

In addition, Consular officers at U.S. Embassies and Consulates provide visa services to relatives of U.S. citizens seeking to immigrate to the United States and to millions of visa applicants seeking to travel temporarily to, or work in, the United States. Improving capabilities to provide visa services in a secure, accurate, and efficient manner results in increased legitimate travel while securing borders in support of national security. CA coordinates with foreign governments and interagency partners such as the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), the Department of Justice (DOJ), the Department of the Treasury, and the intelligence and law enforcement communities to protect U.S. borders from threats at home and abroad.

2. Bureau Strategic Framework

Bureau Goal 1: Protect the lives and serve the interests of U.S. citizens overseas through the provision of efficient and effective services.

- **Bureau Objective 1.1:** By September 30, 2024, timely and more efficient delivery of consular services information to U.S. citizens is improved.
- **Bureau Objective 1.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA's technological ability to provide routine services to U.S. citizens overseas is enhanced.

Bureau Goal 2: Enhance the customer experience while improving the security and efficiency of Passport Services.

- **Bureau Objective 2.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA will reduce and maintain passport processing times to pre-pandemic timeframes.
- **Bureau Objective 2.2:** By September 30, 2024, CA will improve its capabilities to provide passport services to U.S. citizens.
- **Bureau Objective 2.3:** By September 30, 2024, CA will improve equity in passport and CRBA application forms and accessibility to passport and citizenship services.

Bureau Goal 3: Innovate our processes to facilitate legitimate travel while promoting secure U.S. borders.

- **Bureau Objective 3.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA will increase the number of adjudications to exceed 13 million nonimmigrant visa and 600,000 immigrant visa applications, which would considerably exceed FY 2019 adjudications.
- **Bureau Objective 3.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA will implement at least three new programs that strengthen our ability to secure the border and facilitate travel.

Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Goal: Improve organizational and resource capacity in support of consular services.

- **Management Objective 1.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA provides robust, reliable, and secure information technology systems by deploying enterprise-wide solutions that can adapt to users' changing business needs.
- **Management Objective 1.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA will stabilize and maintain a Consular and Border Security Programs account capable of supporting state-of-the-art routine and emergency consular services and products.
- **Management Objective 1.3:** By September 30, 2026, CA's customer experience (CX) and diversity, equity, inclusion and accessibility (DEIA and Equity) systems and strategies for consular personnel and customers are improved.
- **Management Objective 1.4:** By September 30, 2026, CA will institutionalize and expand its professional development opportunities for all consular personnel.
- **Management Objective 1.5:** By September 30, 2026, CA will enhance consular personnel's ability to prevent fraud and promote the integrity of consular services.
- **Management Objective 1.6:** By September 30, 2026, increase Congress and the public's knowledge of consular services and policies.

3. Bureau Goals, Objectives, and Sub-Objectives

Bureau Goal 1: Protect the lives and serve the interests of U.S. citizens overseas through the provision of efficient and effective services.

- **Bureau Goal 1 Description:** This goal supports the State-USAID Joint Strategic Plan (JSP) Goal 5, Serve U.S. citizens around the world and facilitate international exchange and connectivity. Since 1790, protecting the lives and interests of U.S. citizens has been the Department's highest priority. CA assists U.S. citizens overseas by documenting life's milestones from birth to death. Consular personnel assist U.S. citizens affected by crises, including but not limited to, natural disasters, political strife, and medical emergencies. We work diligently to prevent and resolve international parental child abduction and improve intercountry adoption throughout the world. Advances in technology have created both new opportunities for, and challenges to, the way CA interacts with U.S. citizens. Through the span of this FBS, CA will continue to improve access to safety and security information and develop more efficient ways to quickly disseminate information to reach effectively those traveling and residing abroad.

- **Bureau Objective 1.1:** By September 30, 2024, timely and more efficient delivery of consular services information to U.S. citizens is improved.

- **Bureau Objective 1.1 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.1, as well as Learning Agenda 6.2, to keep U.S. citizens informed of safety and security issues, and is consistent with government-wide Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility efforts in E.O. 13985. CA will also improve its ability to provide consular information in an equitable and accessible manner.

- **Bureau Objective 1.1 Risk Considerations:** CA must stabilize the CBSP account to ensure consistent staffing and funding to maintain its delivery of information to U.S. citizens. Failure to address equity and accessibility in our information products will result in underserved populations not receiving needed critical safety and security information.

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- **Bureau Objective 1.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA's technological ability to provide routine services to U.S. citizens overseas is enhanced.

- **Bureau Objective 1.2 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.1 and addresses services to U.S. citizens abroad and Learning Agenda Question 6.3 on improving capabilities to provide services. CA must continue to modernize technological efforts to efficiently provide consular services.
- **Bureau Objective 1.2 Risk Considerations:** CA must stabilize the CBSP account to ensure consistent staffing and funding for IT modernization. Failure to improve IT and financial capabilities will leave CA unable to meet expectations for electronic services.

Bureau Goal 2: Enhance the customer experience while improving the security and efficiency of passport services.

- **Bureau Goal 2 Description:** CA will prioritize the enhancement of the customer experience while improving passport security and timely service to U.S. citizens. This will be demonstrated by meeting CA's service level commitments. CA will pilot online passport renewal services as one element of our continual efforts to improve the customer experience. CA will also reduce high processing times experienced during the pandemic, enhance passport book security, and improve equity and accessibility in passport services.
- **Bureau Objective 2.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA will reduce and maintain passport processing times to pre-pandemic timeframes.

- **Bureau Objective 2.1 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.2, advance U.S. interests by facilitating legitimate travel to and from the United States. The Department's Learning Agenda and E.O. 13571 on "Streamlining Service Delivery and Improving Customer Service" addresses and justifies prioritizing the reduction of high processing times customers have been experiencing during the pandemic. CA provides significant services directly to the public and is considered a High Impact Service Provider by the Office of Management and Budget. CA strives to ensure timely service to U.S. citizens, as demonstrated by our service-level commitments and measured performance against those commitments.
- **Bureau Objective 2.1 Risk Considerations:** Unanticipated increases in passport demand, or unforeseen natural, public, health, or other crises impacting CA's workforce could lead to delays in CA's ability to provide timely services. Unforeseen sustained system outages or cyber security issues could impact the timely provision of passport services. Operational failures or significant delays on the part of our service partners could impact provision of passport services.
- **Bureau Objective 2.2:** By September 30, 2024, CA will improve its capabilities to provide passport services to U.S. citizens.
 - **Bureau Objective 2.2 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.2, advance U.S. interests by facilitating legitimate travel to and from the United States. It expands on ongoing efforts to deliver more secure travel documents to U.S. citizen travelers and an online passport renewal experience. The Department's Learning Agenda and E.O. 13571 on "Streamlining Service Delivery and Improving Customer Service" address and justify prioritizing capabilities to enhance access to passport services and expand digital engagement opportunities.
 - **Bureau Objective 2.2 Risk Considerations:** CA's current funding model relies on consular fees the Department retains. Technological process improvements necessary to expand digital improvement opportunities depend on the availability of resources to prioritize such efforts.

- **Bureau Objective 2.3:** By September 30, 2024, CA will improve equity in passport and CRBA application forms and accessibility to passport and citizenship services.
 - **Bureau Objective 2.3 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 3.2, advance equity, accessibility, and rights relative to E.O. 13985 on “Advancing Racial Equity and Support for Underserved Communities Through the Federal Government” and justifies prioritizing capabilities to enhance access to passport services.
 - **Bureau Objective 2.3 Risk Considerations:** CA’s failure to adjust its organizational culture to reflect broader social trends would result in failing underserved and/or marginalized communities and continue practices the administration seeks to rectify.

Bureau Goal 3: Innovate our processes to facilitate legitimate travel while securing U.S. borders.

- **Bureau Goal 3 Description:** CA formulates and implements policy relating to immigration and visa services and ensures responsive and efficient provision of visa services overseas. Consular officers at U.S. Embassies and Consulates provide visa services to millions of applicants and relatives of U.S. citizens seeking to immigrate to the United States. Improving capabilities to provide visa services in a secure, accurate, and efficient manner results in increased legitimate travel while securing borders in support of national security. Issuing visas and facilitating travel to the United States for immigration, temporary work, and tourism are crucial to continued U.S. economic recovery and to President Biden’s promise of a foreign policy for the middle class. CA relies on internal and interagency information technology to screen visa applicants effectively. Partner agencies provide data, analysis, and experience with which CA can continue to improve processes. Foreign governments share critical security information. As immigration trends and global threats evolve, CA will continue its collaboration with the interagency community and foreign partners. Efforts to improve visa processing will provide better services to visa applicants and U.S. citizens while increasing the integrity of the process.

- **Bureau Objective 3.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA will increase the number of adjudications to exceed 13 million nonimmigrant visa and 600,000 immigrant visa applications, which would considerably exceed FY 2019 adjudications.
 - **Bureau Objective 3.1 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.2, advance U.S. interests by facilitating legitimate travel to and from the United States and supports the expansion of legitimate travel, including for international exchanges. Providing visa services in a secure, accurate, and efficient manner results in improved customer service and protects U.S. borders. Efforts to improve processing will also improve efficiency and increase the integrity of providing visa services.
 - **Bureau Objective 3.1 Risk Considerations:** Inadequate resources, to include under-resourcing of CA's IT systems, and global crises present risks to CA's ability to provide visa services and to ensure U.S. national security. Additionally, CA's revenue source is vulnerable to demand volatility that is inherently reactive to economic and political events, natural disasters, public health and security crises, Congressional action, and other factors beyond CA's control. CA must stabilize the CBSP account to ensure consistent staffing and funding to maintain its delivery of visa services and the requisite IT modernization.
- **Bureau Objective 3.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA will protect U.S. borders by implementing at least three new programs that strengthen our ability to secure the border and facilitate travel.

- **Bureau Objective 3.2 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports JSP Strategic Objective 5.2, advance U.S. interests by facilitating legitimate travel to and from the United States and emphasizes secure borders while opening doors to travelers and immigrants. The United States continues to be an international beacon of freedom and economic opportunities. While welcoming immigrants and temporary visitors, we must continue to avert potential threats and harm to the United States by maintaining secure U.S. borders. Reinforcing efforts that maintain and improve visa security and the integrity of the adjudication process includes a range of activities and interagency coordination and cooperation. CA relies on internal and interagency information technology to screen visa applicants effectively. Partner agencies provide data, analysis, and experience with which CA can improve processes and foreign governments share critical security information. Domestic visa renewal, a service highly sought by the private sector, is a White House priority. The future of international travel will rely on digital documents. Launching a foil-less visa, the Digital Visa Authorization (DVA) will enable the Bureau to retain applicants' passports for a much shorter time and removes the opportunity for malafide actors to alter a physical visa foil.
- **Bureau Objective 3.2 Risk Considerations:** Resource constraints could impact CA's efforts to implement these three projects and present risks to CA's ability to contribute to the operations of the National Vetting Center and other supporting agencies. Constraints within partner agencies also affect and pose risks to CA's operations. Airline capacities may affect the ability to launch DVA as planned.

4. Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Goal

Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Goal 1 | Improve organizational and resource capacity in support of consular services.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Goal 1 Description:** CA has distinguished itself as a pioneer within the Department in leadership and management. Each directorate and office support CA's strategic mission while actively instituting systems to improve management, developing clearer tactical direction, and enhancing transparency. CA strives to be a responsive, innovative, and lean organization, benefiting domestic and international customers.

CA develops, deploys, and supports IT solutions to digitize processes to support the Department's consular services, from concept to product or service delivery.

CA ensures the efficient use of Consular and Border Security Programs (CBSP) resources to meet the bureau's strategic goals. CA provides critical services to U.S. citizens and foreign nationals, domestically and abroad, while relying upon variable revenue streams to fund those activities. CA does not retain all the fees collected and, for certain services, charges less than the full cost of the service. A stable and healthy CBSP account will allow the bureau to stay current in a changing world, support the nation's security and economy, and help U.S. citizens in crisis. CA is expanding its use of data and program evaluations to inform management decisions.

CA incorporates and invests in improving the equitable access to consular services for U.S. citizens and foreign nationals seeking visas. Overseas consular personnel are often the only State Department officials the public encounters. CA infuses the Administration's priorities of improved customer experience as well as equity and accessibility in consular services during all contacts with the public. As part of this work, CA will continue to develop a workforce that maximizes the strengths and talents of personnel and incorporates diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility principles into daily operations. In addition, CA will continue to invest in its workforce to enhance executive readiness and ensure appropriate consular staffing, with an eye towards improving diversity at all levels.

Consular fraud prevention is a bureau-wide effort. Not only does it address and prevent external fraud by passport and visa applicants, this cross-cutting effort addresses and prevents mis/malfeasance by consular personnel within CA.

CA communicates with Congress and the public to increase awareness of policies and procedures for consular services. Doing so provides information Congress needs to conduct oversight and support, prepares the public to apply for passport and visas, and keeps international travelers informed about safety and security.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.1:** By September 30, 2026, CA provides robust, reliable, and secure information technology systems by deploying enterprise-wide solutions that can adapt to users' changing business needs.
 - **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.1 Justification and Linkages:** This objective supports CA's response to Learning Agenda Question 6.3 on improving CA's capacity to provide modern, secure, and accessible consular services. Consular information technology systems are the backbone of CA's operations. Achieving this strategic objective directly results in more efficient and effective processes throughout the Bureau. Continued modernization of CA's information systems is crucial to providing straightforward, simplified transactions, and improved online and in-person interfaces. Better management of systems and records will improve performance, monitor compliance, and inform data driven, strategic decisions.
 - **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.1 Risk Considerations:** This objective faces various risks, including insufficient financial resources, cybersecurity attacks, and delays in contract award processing that defer modernization efforts.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.2:** By September 30, 2026, CA will stabilize and maintain a healthy Consular and Border Security Programs account to provide state-of-the-art routine and emergency consular services and products.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.2 Justification and Linkages:** CA is primarily a fee-funded bureau that must manage its resources effectively to sustain consular operations. CA's primary budgetary challenges are 1) CA sets fees at cost of service, but does not retain all fees charged, with the balance remitted to the U.S. Treasury; 2) CA does not collect fees for all services provided and provides some services at less than cost; and 3) CA's legal expenditure authorities for revenue streams are restricted. In addition, CA's revenue sources are vulnerable to demand volatility that is inherently reactive to economic and political events, natural disasters, and public health crises (e.g., COVID pandemic), security issues, and other factors beyond CA's control. This management objective supports Joint Strategic Goal 5 on U.S. Citizens around the world and facilitating international exchange and connectivity.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.2 Risk Considerations:** The fee-funded financial structure directly impacts CA's ability to provide routine and emergency consular services and staff at appropriate levels. An under-resourced bureau cannot effectively or adequately provide citizens, passport, and visa services to U.S. citizens and foreign nationals. There are significant and direct resource implications when demand fluctuates. In addition, the rule-making process for adjusting fee authorities to recover actual consular operational costs is time intensive, cumbersome, and can be impacted by successive Administrations' priorities, resulting in substantial revenue shortages.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.3:** By September 30, 2026, CA's customer experience (CX) and diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility (DEIA and Equity) systems and strategies for consular personnel and customers are improved.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.3 Justification and Linkages:** Executive Orders (E.O.) 13985, 14058, and 14091 require federal agencies to take steps to improve equity and customer experience in federal government services. CA has invested in customer-focused, human-centered design and improvement processes that improve customer service and increase equitable access to consular services. The implementation of these E.O.s builds on CA's existing culture of continuous learning to ensure that the customer experience is central to CA's work. To properly improve customer experience, CA must ensure that overseas consular sections and domestic agencies are appropriately staffed, trained, and equipped to provide exceptional consular services and products. CA sees developing and maintaining a diverse consular workforce and cultivating an inclusive, equitable, and accessible workplace as a key component to ensuring that consular services are equitable and accessible. Maintaining an equitable and accessible work environment further empowers our diverse staff to successfully implement customer experience initiatives.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.3 Risk Considerations:** CA's organizational culture encourages diversity, inclusion, equity, and access to opportunities for all consular personnel. Customer experience and Equity are parallel issues that have important linkages to how CA provides and improves consular services. If CA is unable to effectively address customer experience and DEIA goals, its ability to successfully engage in people-to-people diplomacy is diminished. In an era where prospective employees evaluate where to work, successful implementation of DEIA is needed to recruit and retain a diverse workforce.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.4:** By September 30, 2026, CA institutionalizes and expands its professional development opportunities for consular personnel.
 - **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.4 Justification and Linkages:**
Developing and maintaining a high-functioning and motivated consular workforce supports CA's mission to protect and serve U.S. citizens and to facilitate a secure, effective visa and passport adjudication processes. CA ensures that overseas consular sections and domestic agencies are appropriately staffed, equipped, and supplied. CA identifies and manages staffing gaps or surges in workload domestically and abroad to maintain standards of timely service. CA prioritizes professional development and has created tools, resources, and learning opportunities that reinforce the CA Leadership and Management Tenets and promote the CA Management Framework. Preparing consular personnel for senior positions in the Department also ensures that the bureau has the leadership expertise to meet future challenges and achieve strategic goals.
 - **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.4 Risk Considerations:** If the Department were to constrain hiring, this could severely hamper the Bureau's ability to protect and serve U.S. citizens and facilitate secure and effective visa and passport adjudication processes. CA must stabilize the CBSP account to avoid a repeat of the hiring and training freezes necessitated during the COVID pandemic. CA's ability to hire, train, and retain consular personnel is contingent on a sustained funding source. Failure to invest in our workforce will leave consular personnel unprepared for higher levels of responsibilities within CA and the Department.
- **Management Objective 1.5:** By September 30, 2026, CA will enhance consular personnel's ability to prevent fraud and promote the integrity of consular services.

- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective Justification 1.5:** Deterring, detecting, and investigating citizenship and visa fraud and malfeasance is essential to safeguard national security. The ingenuity, resources, and globally present nature of criminal entities that engage in fraud pose a serious risk to the integrity of consular processes. To mitigate that risk, CA believes in a robust and multi-faceted approach that engages all consular personnel and relies on close coordination between fraud prevention managers, consular leadership, and all other facets of consular operations. Data analytics provide insight into worldwide trends and identifies links between cases. These data are used to develop post-specific fraud prevention plans responsive to the latest and most pertinent threats, trends, and techniques.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective Risk Consideration 1.5:** Without fraud prevention and consular integrity measures, the integrity and security of U.S. travel documents, as well as the integrity of consular decisions, is undermined, which in turn threatens U.S. borders and the safety and security of U.S. citizens.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective 1.6:** By September 30, 2026, increase Congress and the public's knowledge of consular services and policies.
- **Bureau Cross-Cutting Management Objective Justification 1.6:** CA communicates with Congress and the public to maximize awareness of policies and procedures for consular services. Doing so provides Congress the information they need to conduct oversight and support, prepares the public to apply for passport and visas, and informs international travelers about safety and security. Being open and transparent and providing accessible services to customers contributes to CA's positive reputation. CA shares information regarding citizen support and visa services with Congress through assistance with constituent inquiries and proactive outreach to Congressional staff. Outreach to Congressional offices increases Congressional familiarity with consular services and procedures.

- **Management Objective Risk Consideration 1.6:** Risks to the achievement of this objective include delays in adoption of new technologies that further communication objectives and significant changes in Congressional policy/laws impacting CA operations.